

Sole-Source Justification for Mercyhurst University

Founded in 1992, Mercyhurst University's Ridge College of Intelligence Studies and Applied Sciences has heavily invested in strategic intelligence, data science and cyber security, including a cyber lab which NSIC has relied upon to improve the overall reliability of its intelligence production. Mercyhurst University works to hone and professionalize the skills of students in Intelligence Studies and Computer Information Science programs. All academic levels participate to apply their skills in a variety of collaborative intelligence and data-driven projects.

Mercyhurst University and the National Space Intelligence Center (NSIC), formally the National Air and Space Intelligence Center, Space, Missiles and Forces Intelligence Groups' working relationship began as early as 2009 and was formalized with an Education Partnership Agreement (EPA) in 2021. Mercyhurst University's Ridge College of Intelligence Studies and Applied Science builds intelligence tradecraft "capstone" courses around unclassified research and analysis topics submitted by various intelligence agencies and corporations. Capstone projects involve open-source research and analysis on political, social, technological, and economic factors related to specific key intelligence questions (provided by NSIC analysts), and their implications to US decision making. Benefits to the agency are twofold: 1) Research project provide insight into foreign plans, programs, capabilities, forecasts, strategy, doctrine, intent, perceptions, reactions, redlines, thresholds for escalation. This frees NSIC analysts to focus their efforts on other topics. 2) The source list for each research project is provided to the agency's open-source analysis squadron to improve mission efficacy.

Mercyhurst's national security, rather than homeland security, scope focuses on a global perspective with students conducting country stability studies and examining foreign policy impacts on the U.S. This aligns more with the National Space Intelligence Centers mission, goals, and requirements for this project. Additionally, Mercyhurst approaches intelligence in a holistic perspective; in this case, examining the economy, social unrest, crime, governance, policies, and foreign relations; which is better suited when assessing the safety and stability of a country, particularly in the long-term.

Due to these factors and Mercyhurst's ongoing and mutually beneficial relationship with the National Space Intelligence Center, this is the ideal university to work with to produce the product required by this contract. It is in the Centers best interest to continue to bolster this relationship to produce the quality of a product that can meet the Center needs and standards.

